UI/UX design

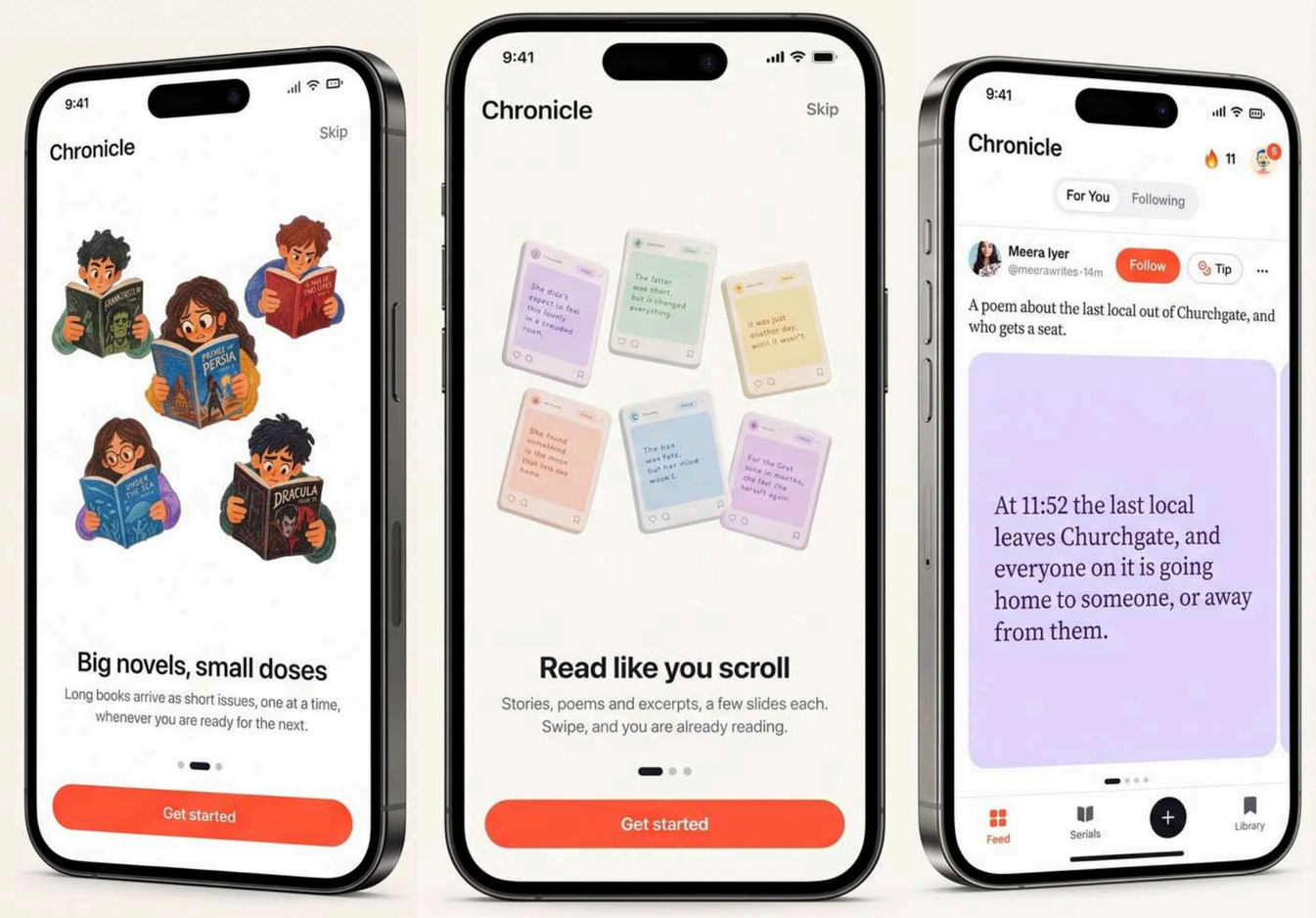
Solo project

Timeline- 4 weeks

Chronicle

Fall back in love with reading





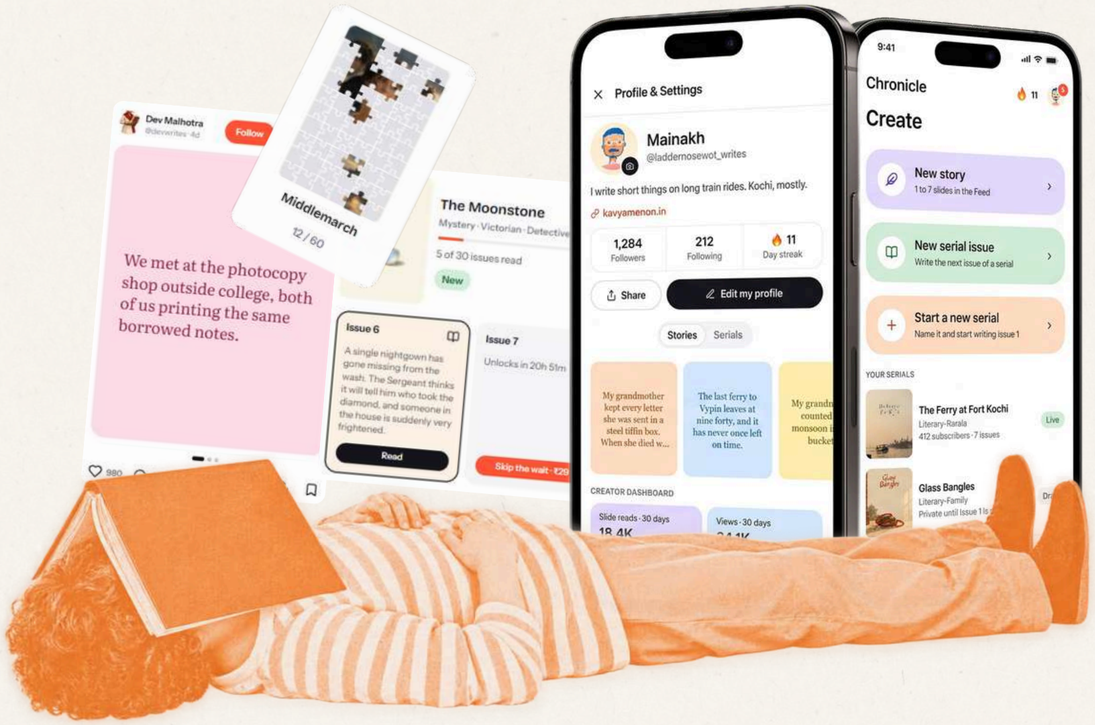
Overview

Chronicle is for people who love the idea of reading but struggle to find the time or commitment.

Fiction in a few slides, as easy as scrolling.

Longer stories come in quick, 5-minute episodes on your chosen days, each bringing you closer to an ultimate reward.

And yes, you can share your own stories too !!



Let's see how Chronicle came into being →

Research (Part 1 of 2)

Decline in the reading habit but not the interest for reading



40%

Drop in time Indians spend reading for leisure

5.4% to 3.8%

Indians who read for leisure, 2019 to 2024

5 to 10 min

Average daily time Indians spend reading for personal interest. Fewer than 5% read on any given day.

510B to 1.1T hours

Time Indians spent on phones, 2019 to 2024



80%

Young Indians see reading as essential for growth, while 60% want to read for leisure.

4 to 6 bought vs 1 to 2 finished

Books urban Indians buy each year vs books they finish

Interviewing 26 passive readers in the age group of 20-35

They want to read. They buy books, download ebooks and save titles on Goodreads.
Many start a book, but continuous effort and lack of time impedes a sustainable habit

Research (Part 2 of 2)

Major bottlenecks of traditional reading



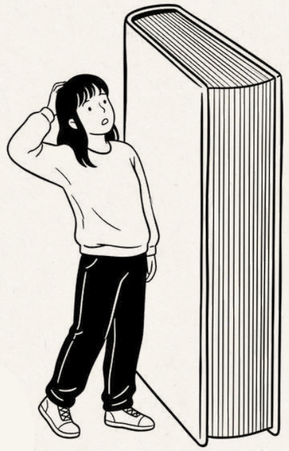
The reward from reading takes time

Traditional books take 30-70 pages to build give the reward of reading which is too long for the modern reader



The story slips away

Gaps in reading sessions makes it easy to loose track of storyline and thus drop offs



The book looks big & lengthy

A 350 page book, or '11 hours left' on an ebook, reads as a large time commitment.



Reading sessions require long sittings

Free time often comes in 2 to 8 minute gaps. A typical chapter takes 20 to 40 minutes.

Insight mapping



Interest and goodwill for pleasure reading is very much present

- 60% of readers are casual, but they account to only ~30% of completed books
- Consensus about reading is positive, but consistency to completion remains a challenge

NielsenIQ BookData / GfK (2025)



Books ask too much effort from a new, casual reader

- On Goodreads, about 15% quit a book before page 50 and 28% quit before page 100
- Passive consumption pro bono has reduced the baseline cognitive effort casual readers are willing to put into reading

Bruineberg, World psychiatry, Goodreads, Primary research



Reading hasn't died, it has changed into a different form

- People are reading text daily in the form of reddit stories, Medium articles, Substack, X and Threads.
- Reading shorter content with instant closure is the new format of reading for casuals

PrimaryInterview results



Traditional books take too long to complete, so reader drop out

- An average book takes 3-8 hours to read cover to cover
- India's Time Use Survey data suggests leisure reading is facing a crisis of time, not a change in taste.

Inc42, Deccanherald, Primary research

Decision to scope down





Target user : 20-28 yr old young indians

They have reading intent but weak completion

They have started their careers and can afford their wants

They are at an adaptable life stage

They face time pressure for work or higher studies

Have a stronger personal reason to read for pleasure.

Target literary type : Fiction

India’s fiction revenue grew 30.7% in 2024, the highest across 18 countries.

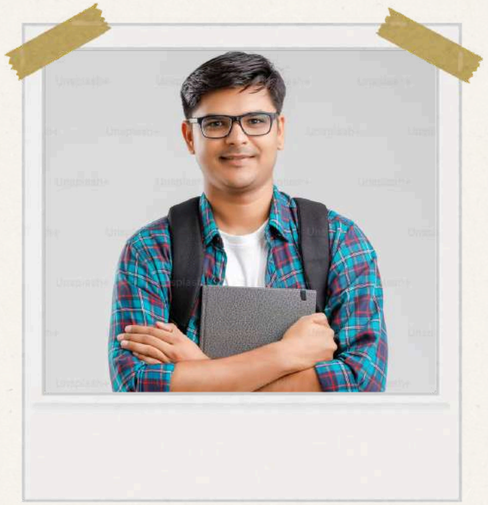
Fiction represented 65% of Gen Z’s reading in a Library Journal survey

Fiction creates a stronger emotional pull to keep reading.

In Kobo’s data, fiction sees higher completion as 63.5% finish mystery novels vs. 37.8% for non-fiction

Persona 1

College student with heavy coursework load



Manan Tiwari

21

Studies B.Tech (3rd year)

New Delhi

Background : Manan loves reading and enjoys the euphoria of finishing a good story, especially during college breaks.
But on regular days, coursework leaves him too exhausted and short on time to read, so he defaults to passive scrolling instead.

Needs and wants

Needs a reading structure which will suit his routine which will enable him to keep pursuing the hobby

Wants the reward of reading to be fast without compromising on the experience of fulfilment

Pain points

College coursework leaves him unable to focus or get the time to do any reading

His mind after the day is exhausted which makes it difficult for him to put in more effort to read

Defaults to low-effort scrolling in his free time, making it harder to build a reading habit.

Persona 2

Workaholic IT professional



Kartik Banerjee

26

Junior Data analyst

Kolkata

Background : A demanding 9–5 leaves him little time or energy to read. Inspired by colleagues and the joy he had on reading a story, he wants to build a reading habit but sees books as too much of a commitment of time and effort to start, despite genuinely wanting to read

Needs and wants

- Needs to find a reading regime that will fit in his busy and stressful lifestyle
- Needs stories in text format, as audio lacks the immersion and fulfilment he gets from reading himself.
- Wants an effortless way to start reading while still experiencing the same euphoria as the story he loved.

Pain points

- The starting of building the habit of reading feels too difficult
- The stressful routine leaves no mental space required for a reading session

Market analysis

	Feature	Gap for a casual reader
Storytel	A large library of audiobooks and ebooks.	A paid plan is required to start, making it harder to try.
Pratilipi	A large home for Indian and independent writers.	Stories span many chapters, so the time commitment is hard
Galatea (by Inkitt)	Immersive romance and fan fiction stories.	Finishing one story takes many long chapters.
Serial reader	Classic novels split into a daily issue.	Public-domain classics only, with 17 minute daily issues that pile up if missed.
Terribly tiny tales	Started with micro fiction shared on Insta and Facebook.	Focused on social commentary and videos, with short fiction no longer central.
SnipFic	A space for new writers to practise short writing.	Lightly moderated beginner writing and 100 word limits create fragmented, repetitive stories.

Some themes were consistent

Across qualitative and quantitative research, persona and their journeys, and market analysis, a few recurring themes consistently emerged.



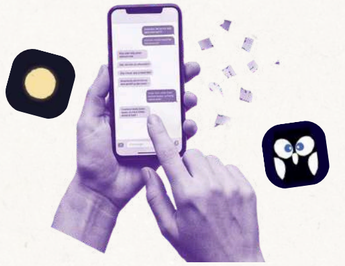
People still want to read, particularly fiction. So the interest is very much alive



The barrier is effort before reward: books demand sustained effort, before the payoff, making readers start but not finish.



Current market of digital books improve access but 15 minute chapters still cater mainly to avid readers.



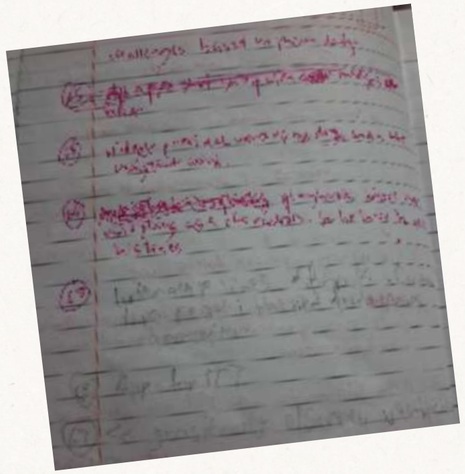
Microfiction is often too short or social commentary-heavy, while chat stories require constant tapping and feel tiring.

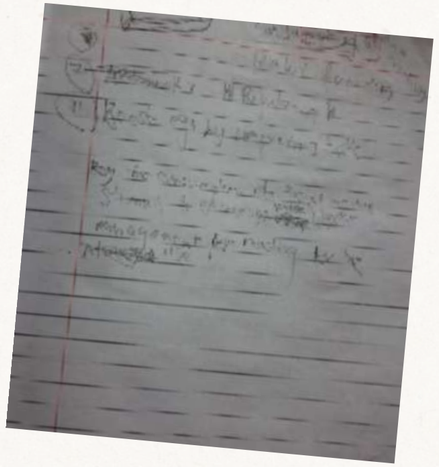
How might we ...

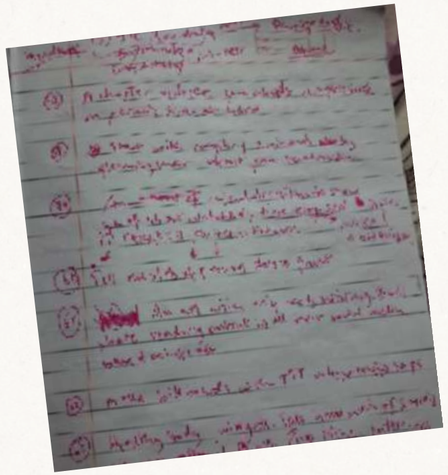
How might we help young Indians, who want to read but struggle to start or drop books midway, find the joy of reading through stories with minimal effort or commitment?

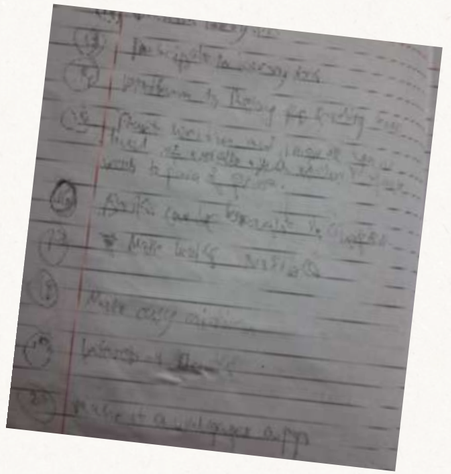
Ideations

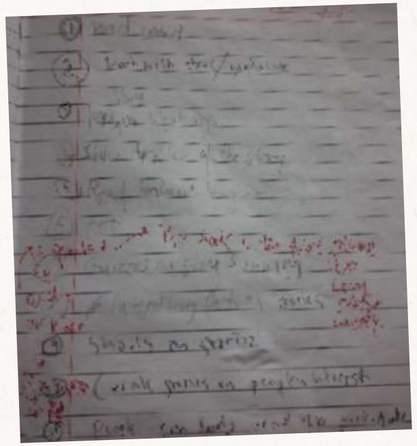
I explored ideations to address the opportunity areas.

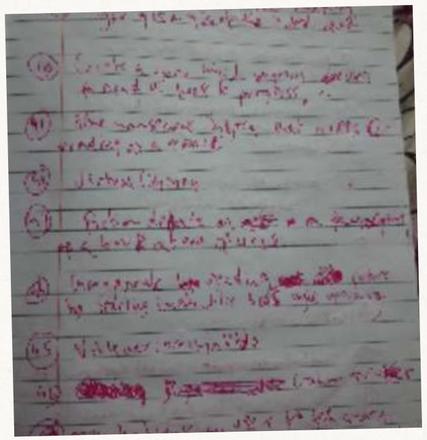


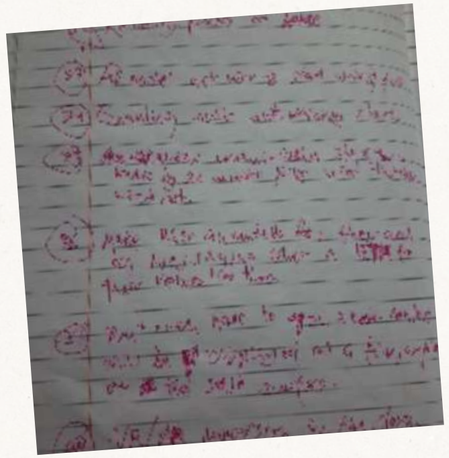


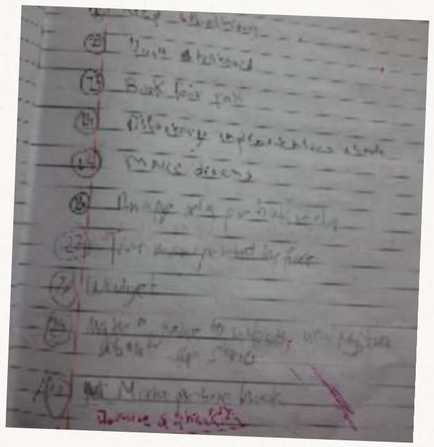


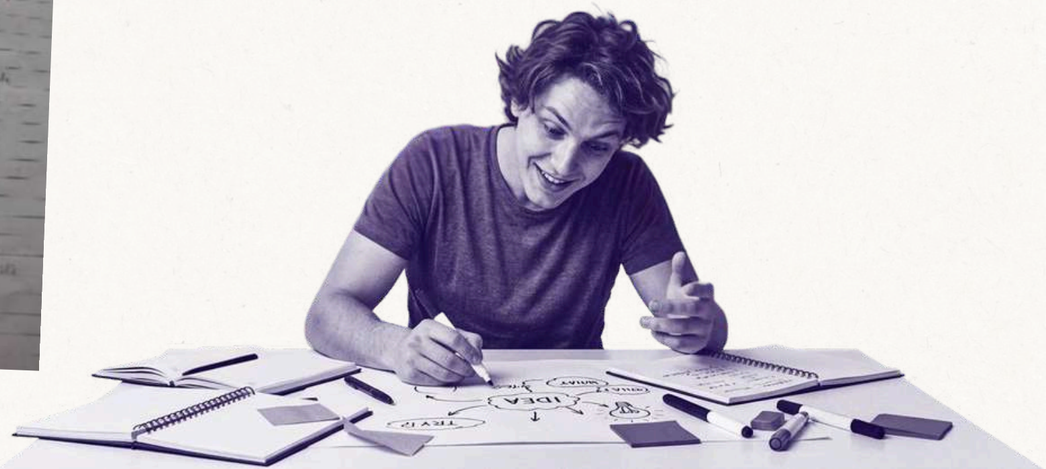








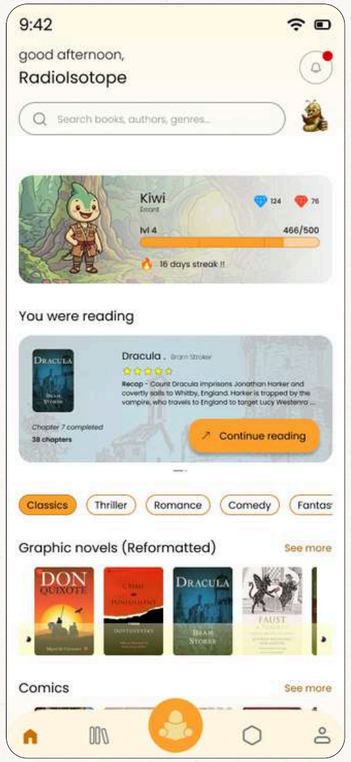


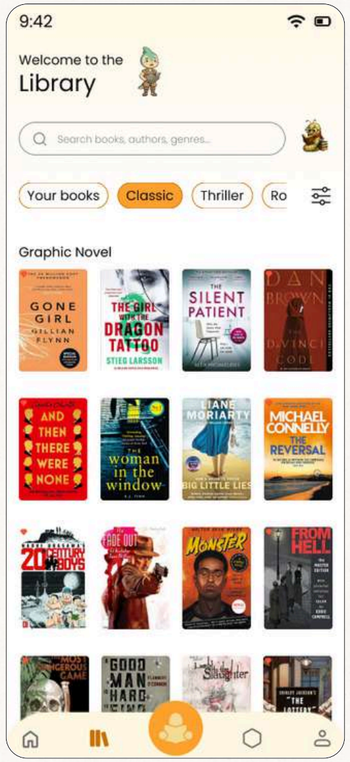


Solution v1

Version one of Chronicle is a reading app that turns stories and classics into short, bite-sized reads or graphic novels with a gamification layer that turns reading minutes into progression in-game, which unlocks rewards and keeps the reader coming back.

Click for [Prototype link to version 1]













Feedback improved my clarity

I evaluated version 1 against the personas, needs, and pain points. Consecutively I did 12 user reviews and a teardown with my design mentor. These feedbacks clarified the gaps in version 1 and **shaped the brainstorming for the second iteration**.



Long onboarding adds much effort before users can start reading.



Reading depends too much on users caring about the **gamification**



Turning **comtemporary books into graphic formats** requires significant investment.



Gamification **shifts focus** from the story to rewards, disrupting immersion and making reading feel like a task.

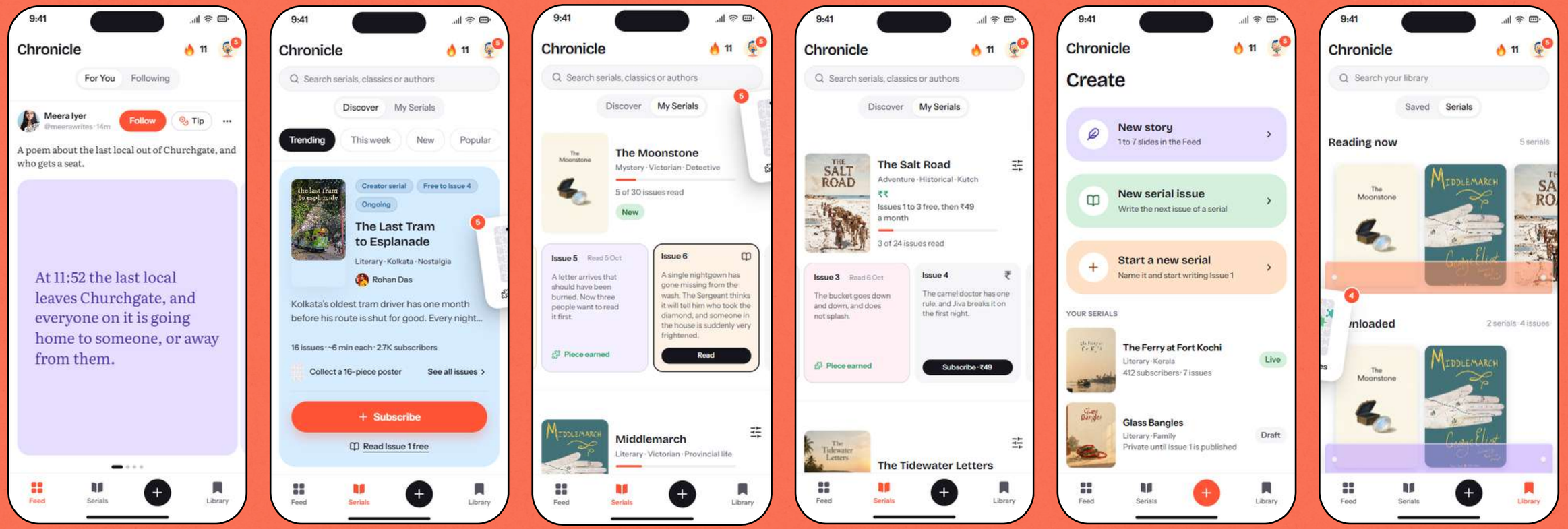


Users still face the **cognitive effort** of reading long format content

Final Solution

Chronicle delivers complete, impactful short stories in 7 slides or fewer, and turns big novels into short issues that drop on the reader's own schedule, so busy young readers can finally start and finish fiction.

Click for [Prototype of Chronicle final version] (prototype link is also presented at page 22)



Key features & Impact (Part 1 of 2)

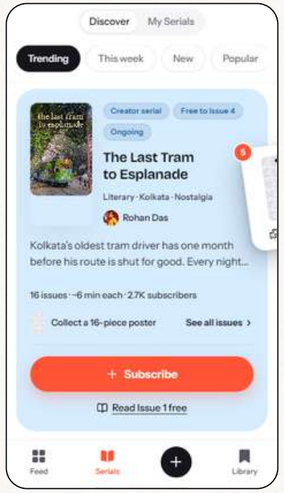


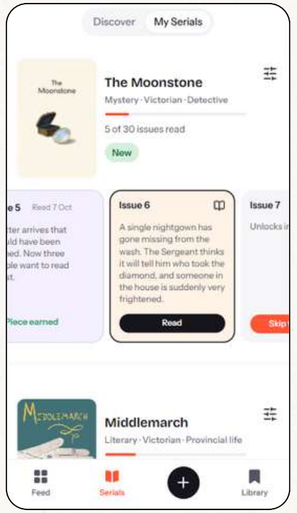
Seven Slide Stories

Design decision
Capped every story at 7 slides, read with a simple swipe.

UX impact
A full story, with its payoff, in under a minute, without endless tapping.

Business impact
Quick wins bring users back daily, raising engagement and retention.





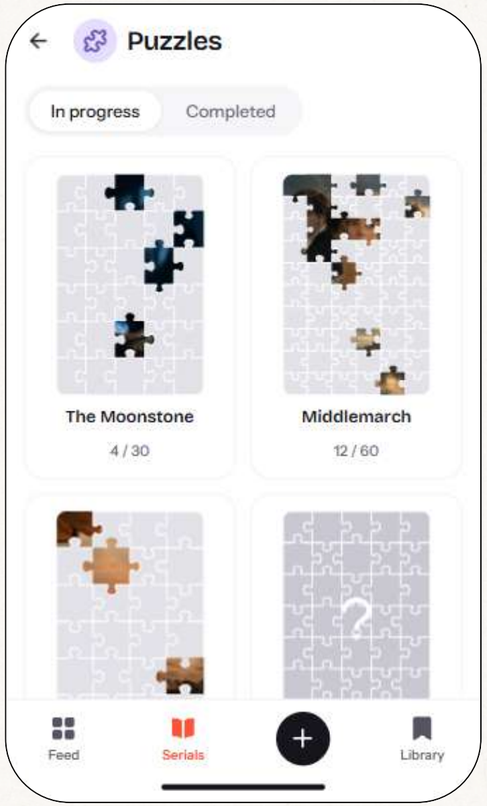
Issue Drops

Design decision
Split long novels into short issues that drop on days the reader picks.

UX impact
No 15 minute chapters; each issue is a small win at the reader's own pace.

Business impact
Scheduled drops create a habit and open paid early access or per-issue unlocks, adding to revenue

Key features & Impact (Part 2 of 2)



Puzzle Rewards

Design decision

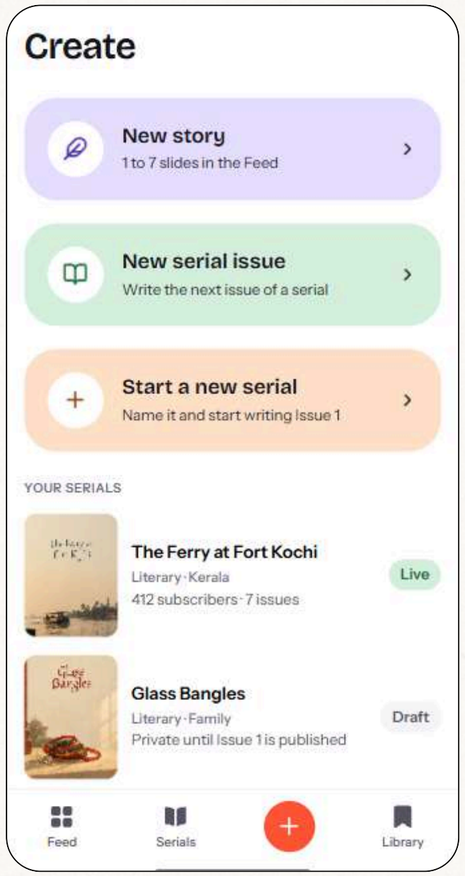
Each issue read unlocks one puzzle piece of a poster of the book being read

UX impact

Reward is offered after every issue, not just at the end of the book.

Business impact

Unfinished puzzles pull readers back, cutting drop-off and lifting serial completion, indicating a higher chance of revenue generation



Write and Share

Design decision

Let anyone publish stories and serials, with monetary tips from readers.

UX impact

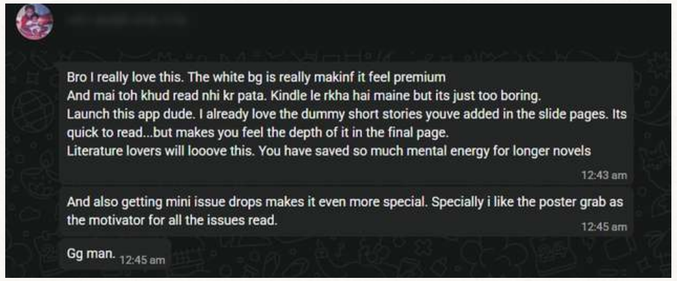
Readers get a steady stream of fresh, relatable stories.

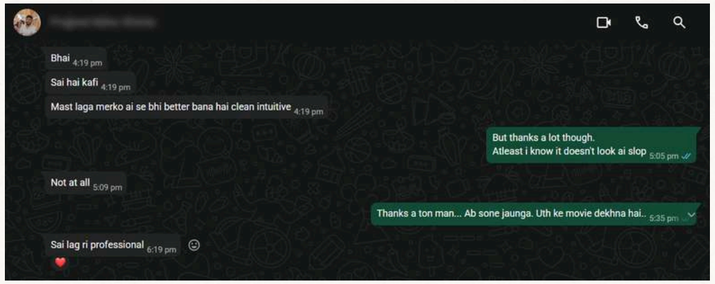
Business impact

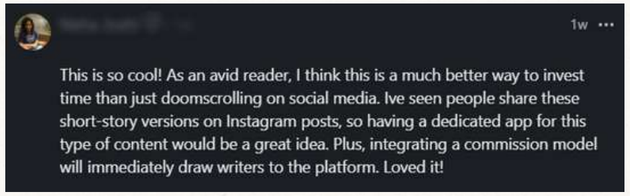
Writers create free content and bring their own audience; tips earn a commission.

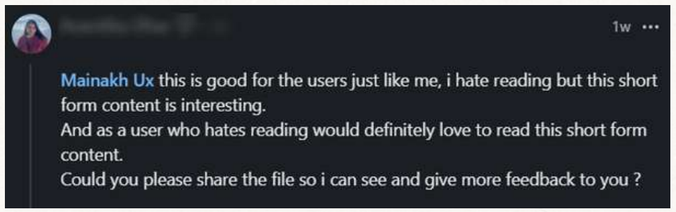
User testing

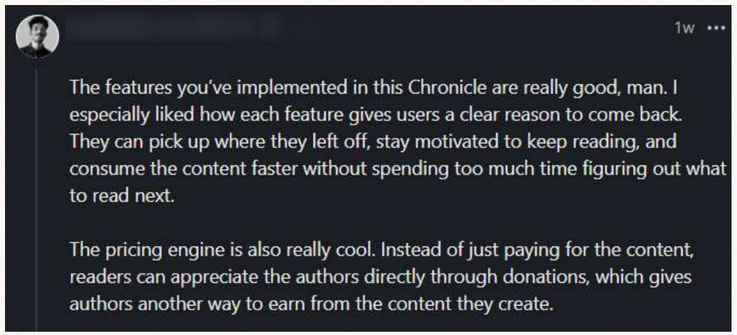
I tested the prototype with 10 users who likes to read but aren't able to follow it. All of them were between the ages of 21-28. All of them liked the product

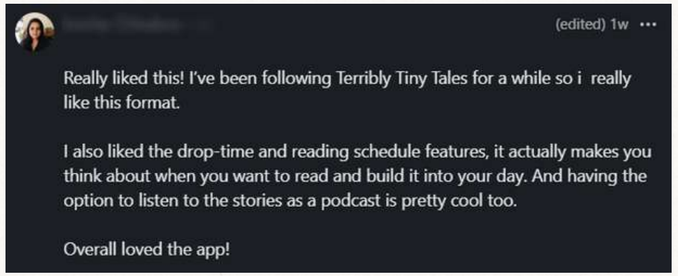


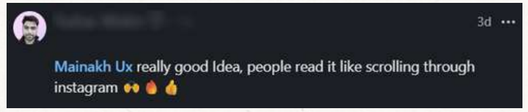




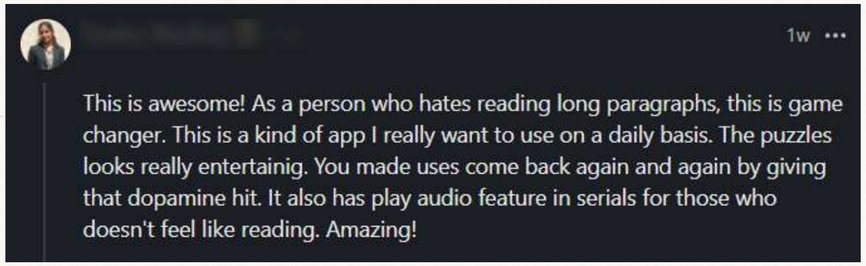


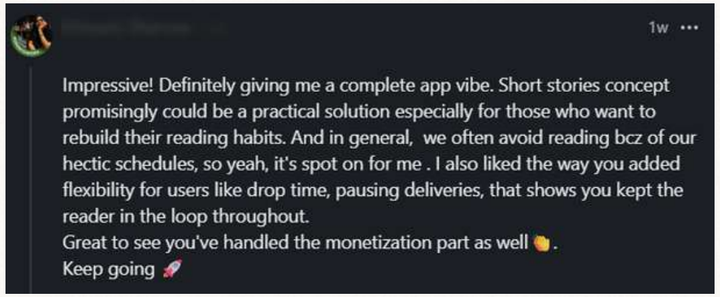












Cost to set up and run



Cost to build (one-time, my estimate)

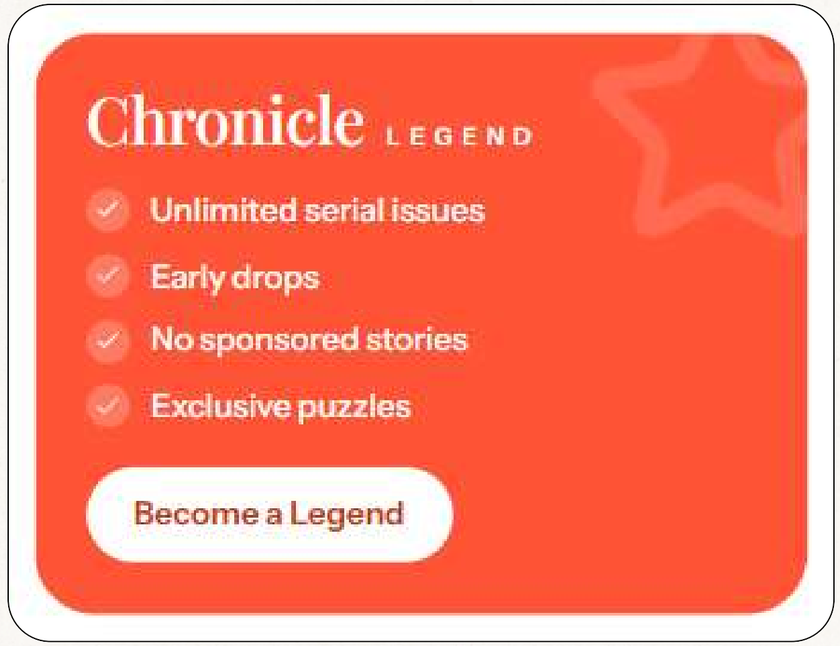
Solo build with AI tools + 1 freelance developer	**₹2–5 lakh**

Cost to run (monthly, my estimate)

	Launch (<10k users)	Growth (~100k users)
Servers, database, storage	₹3–6k	₹15–40k
Content editors (splitting classics, curation)	₹30–50k	₹1–1.5 lakh
Marketing	₹20–50k	₹1–3 lakh
TOTAL	**~₹55k–1 lakh**	**~₹2.5–5 lakh**

Business model (Part 1 of 2)

1

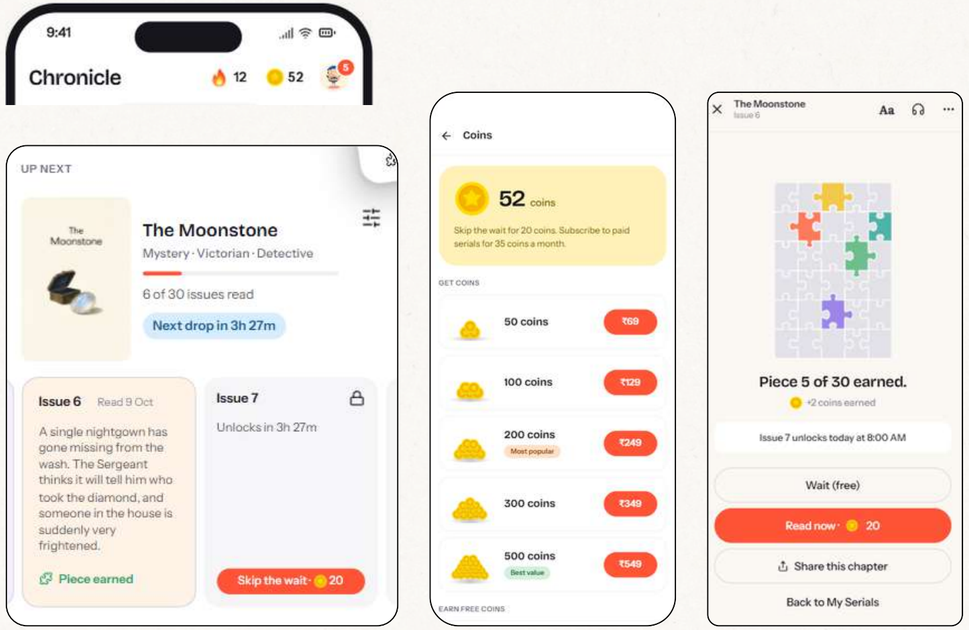


Chronicle Plus (main)

Unlimited serials, early access, ad-free reading, and exclusive puzzles.

₹99–149/month

2



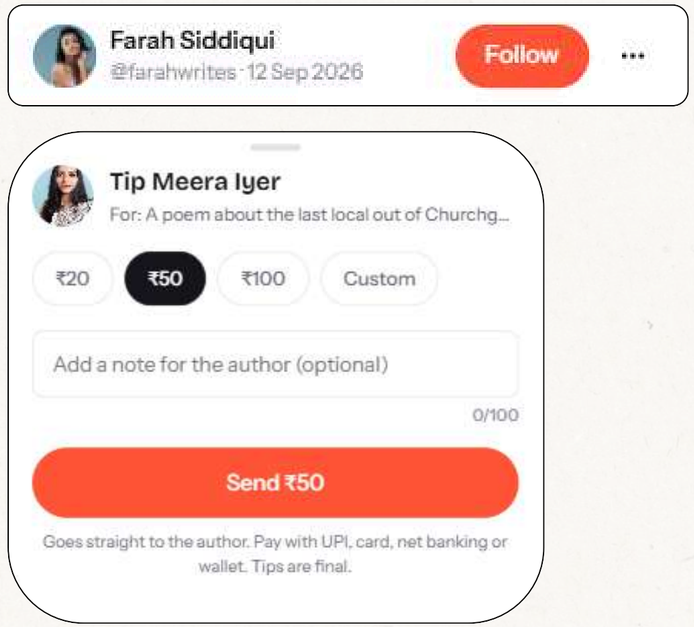
Coins (per-issue unlocks)

Non-subscribers can buy coins to unlock the next issue instantly instead of waiting.

10-25 coins per issue

Business model (Part 2 of 2)

3

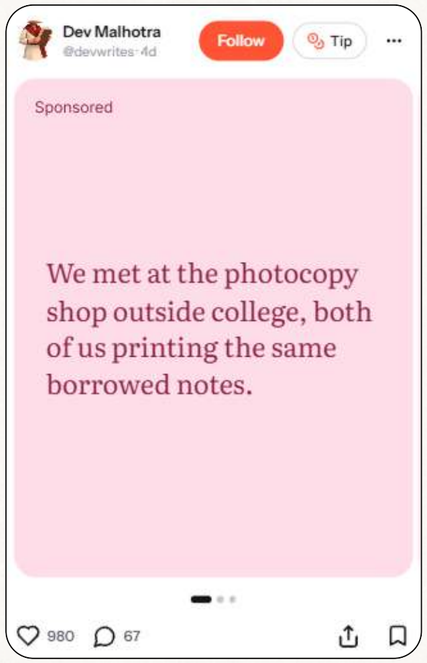


Tips (commission)

Readers tip writers; Chronicle keeps a share

10–20% of each tip

4



Sponsored stories (secondary)

Brands publish labelled 7-slide stories, capped in the feed

Per campaign basis

Learning from the project

1. I learnt to synthesize meaningful insights from a vast amount of research. These insights helped me understand the problem deeply and shaped the vision for solving it.

2. V1 felt perfect until I tested it with users and set my biases aside. Their feedback revealed gaps I hadn’t seen, teaching me that good design means letting user insights guide decisions, not getting attached to my own ideas.

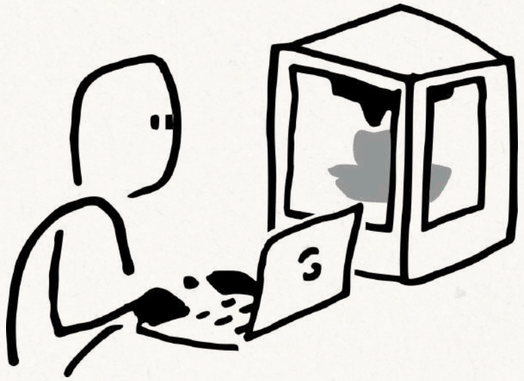
3. I learnt that clarity does not always come at the first glance. I understood the user better as the project progressed and iterative approach helped me design an output for which I am proud of.

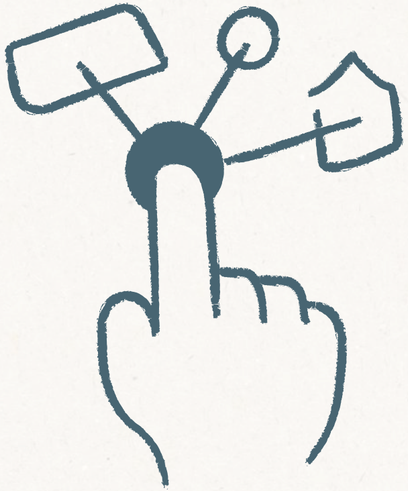


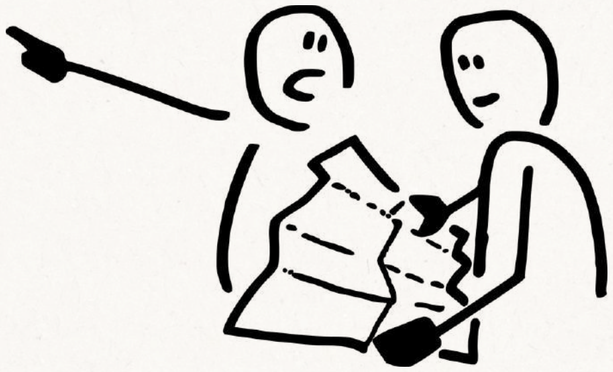
Prototype link of Chronicle

Click here to open the protype link

If you are in the “Present” mode, kindly tap “esc” and then try clicking on the hyperlink







Chronicle

A case study.

